

COSTA RICAN RAINFOREST

A tropical eco-paradise

Costa Rica may be small, but it punches above its size in terms of biodiversity—it contains 5 percent of all species on just 0.3 percent of the world's land mass. The Costa Rican rainforest is a lush tropical jungle, with verdant foliage, rivers, and waterfalls, and teems with an exotic array of animal life. Many of this rainforest's inhabitants are dazzlingly beautiful—butterflies and hummingbirds flit among trees that are adorned with glorious blooms. A diverse array of orchid species are found here, considering the ecoregion's comparably small size.

This bountiful biodiversity is due to Costa Rica's location on the land bridge between North and South America, which gives it representatives from both continents. There is also a range of ecological niches in the country—as well as the rainforest, there are damp cloud forests at higher altitudes, dry forests, and mangrove swamps.

Conservation leader

Costa Rica leads the world in terms of protecting its wild heritage. Around a quarter of the country is designated as national parks or protected areas, and Costa Rica has been praised as a model of responsible ecotourism as people flock here to see the region's myriad of monkey species and unique mammals like sloths. The rate of deforestation has dramatically decreased since the 1960s and some areas have been successfully reforested. Costa Rica has also pioneered payments to landowners for environmental services to support conservation measures and to keep the rainforest intact.



HARPY EAGLE

HUGE HUNTER
The harpy eagle hunts monkeys and sloths among the rainforest canopy. Its short, broad wings make it easier for a bird of its size to maneuver, and its long talons and powerful feet allow it to catch and lift large prey.

HIGH RISER
Trees that emerge high above the main rainforest, such as kapok, benefit from sunlight that doesn't reach lower parts of the rainforest. Nectar-feeding bats pollinate its flowers, and fluffy seeds are blown on the wind to new areas.



KAPOK TREE

IF THE BILL FITS

The flowers of heliconia plants are almost exclusively pollinated by hummingbirds that visit to drink the flowers' rich nectar. The two have coevolved so that heliconias with deeper flower tubes are only pollinated by the species that has a long enough bill.

HELICONIA

More than 50 species of hummingbird

Home to more than 5% of the world's species

